

Methodological Journal 3

Successful African American professionals

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1. How do I feel about the overall success of this interview? Was it generally good, bad, or mixed?

At the end of the second interview, I felt good because I had answers to all my questions. Some answers were repeated from the first interview, and others overlapped with those from the second and third interviews. I was able to get all the answers because I had a good participant to work with.

2. What do I feel good about as I relive this interview?

The hard part of these interviews was some scheduling issues, because I didn't have a lot of free time. I felt like I had to depend on this person to complete my homework assignment. After the second interview, I felt closer to completing my assignments. I have to confess that I just want to get these interviews done. However, John was such a nice guy and was more than willing to work around my schedule.

It seems like John and I are just having a casual conversation, not an interview. John was very comfortable sharing his life story with me.

3. How did I do with the explanation of the research purpose and/or the intent of this particular interview?

At the beginning of my second interview, I mentioned to John again that I am conducting a study on the factors that influence the success of African Americans. I mentioned this in the first and second interviews.

4. How did the interview context enable or constrain the interview process?

I think that the atmosphere has a lot to do with how John responds to my questions. My casual approach works in this case because it just does not feel like I am interviewing John.

5. How did I do in building rapport with the informant? What worked? What didn't?

I have a set of questions that I want to answer. I started my question with casual talk about things going on at our workplace, and slowly steered John's response to my questions. I knew ahead of time what I needed to get out of the interview.

6. What kind of questions did I ask in the interview?

My second interview was different from the first. In the first interview, I just wanted to talk to John. I have a list of already prepared questions, but I have never used them. In the second interview, I wanted to have more structure, so I had a list of questions in front of me. All the questions were from my second interview protocol.

7. What kind of responses did I get?

I got answers to all my questions. I was able to get out of these questions because John was a good participant and willing to share his personal story with me.

8. How did my questions influence the participant's responses?

I have to say that my casual approach works with John. John was very relaxed, because it felt like just a typical day-to-day conversation exchange of ideas with a co-worker.

9. Were my questions leading? Did I put ideas in the informant's head?

Yes. Even though I didn't ask John the questions directly, I was the one who steered John and provoked him to answer my questions. Yes, I did put some ideas in John's head. I just don't want to waste any time.

10. Did I ask closed-ended questions? Open-ended questions?

I started out with open-ended questions. I interrupted John several times when an open-ended question took too long. I would then ask closed-ended questions (or directly).

11. Did I ask multiple questions simultaneously?

I asked one question at a time and tried to prompt John to answer by asking him to agree or disagree.

12. Did I follow up on things the participant brought up that might have been important, even if the question wasn't in my protocol?

The questions in the interview protocol are just guiding questions, and it is not necessary to follow them directly. You care how you get to the answers as long as you get them.

13. How did I handle time within the interview?

Interview over lunch is a good idea, since you have an hour, a typical lunch break. I don't have any time constraints.

14. Was there overlapping talk during the interview? Interruptions? How did I handle these things?

I got a lot of interruptions from the waitress, because it was in a nice, casual restaurant. However, it didn't bother us.

15. Did I use continuers and encouraging words during the interview (e.g., okay, mm-hmmm, um)?

John's favorite word was "Right". John used this word for almost all the responses.

16. Did I treat the interview as a conversation? If so, what did I contribute to the conversation? If not, what was the effect?

From the beginning, I just wanted to have a casual conversation with my participant.

John was able to open up to me because it didn't feel like an interview.

17. Did I evaluate the participant's responses to my questions within the interview? If so, how did the participant respond to my evaluation?

No, I didn't evaluate the participant's responses during the interview. My feelings on all of these: if I don't get an answer in this interview, I will get one in the next interview.

Luckily, I got all mine. Thanks to John!

18. Were my interview questions focused on the purpose of the research?

I mentioned to John about my intention for the interview questions. I also told John what I wanted to get out of the interview.

19. What would I do differently if I were able to do this interview again?

If I had more time to study John, then I would have approached it differently. I would like to spend more time learning about John, talking with his family, and hanging out with him. I didn't get the opportunity in all my interviews. I just didn't have a lot of time.

20. What suggestions for improvement do I have for my own interview techniques?

I have to say, repeat the question to make sure the participant understands it. Repeating the participant's answer (or response) is a good way to clarify the intent of the participant.

21. If I were to interview this participant again, what might I experiment with next time regarding my interviewing style, approach, or method?

I don't see any change between the first, second, or third interview. Most likely, the interview styles are the same.

22. One thing that really surprised me about myself in this interview situation was_____.

There was no surprise. I know myself, and I know what I have to do to finish my class. Subconsciously, I always knew this interview was just a class exercise, not a real study.